from the rest of the people of India. During the sixteenth century, the sultans of Bijapur and Ahmednagar had recruited them to serve in cavalry. Their presence was helpful to the sultans in balancing the political ambitions of the Muslim soldiers in their service. The rocky and mountainous terrain gave protection to the Marathas from invaders. It proved to be advantageous in guerrilla warfare for Marathas.

Bhakti Movement and the Marathas

The spread of the Bhakti movement in Maharashtra helped the Maratha people develop consciousness of their identity and oneness. It promoted a feeling of unity, especially in terms of social equality, among the Marathas. In the Maratha region, the religious leaders were drawn from different social groups. Eknath, Tukaram and Ramdas were the noted Bhakti saints. Tukaram and Ramdas had considerable influence on the life of Shivaji.



Tukaram



Ramdas

Literature and Language of the Marathas

Marathi language and literature also served to develop unity among the people. Hymns composed in the Marathi language by Bhakti saints were sung by people of all castes and classes.

Shivaji

Shivaji, born in 1627, grew up under the care of his mother, Jijabai, who influenced him



Shivaji

with stories from the Hindu epics, Ramayana and the Mahabharatha. Shivaji's teacher and guardian, Dadaji Kondadev, trained him in the art of horse riding, warfare and state administration. At the age of eighteen in 1645, when he had just entered the military career, he successfully captured Kondana, a fort near Poona. The following year, he took the fort of Torna. Then he succeeded in conquering Raigarh, which was rebuilt by him.



Shahji Bhonsle



Jijabai

Shivaji's Confrontation with Sultan of Bijapur

Shivaji became totally independent after the death of his guardian Kondadev (1649). He also got his father's jagir transferred to him, which was earlier looked after by Kondadev. The strength of his army was Mavali foot soldiers. With their help, Shivaji conquered many of the

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